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Equipping Students and Beyond with Sound COVID-19 Knowledge to Survive and Thrive Despite the Pandemic

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Abstract

The COVID-19 pandemic necessitated the understanding of the infodemic for making informed decisions. Limiting the spread of health misinformation and disinformation was the primary goal of the health informatics project awarded to ASIS&T SA Chapter. The project became the recipient of the **ASIS&T "Chapter Innovation of the Year Award 2021"**. A repertoire of online and offline initiatives was carried out with 9 well-researched videos for promoting health informatics. Since August 2021, thousands of academics, librarians, teachers, parents, and students from 16 countries and regions were invited to be science communicators to create and disseminate accurate health information in their areas through an international digital story writing competition. In this poster, we share the strategies of responding to the information crisis, including employing interventions that protect against the infodemic and mitigate its harmful effects.

Introduction

The urgency of the action was especially important to the Asian countries with a population equivalent to 59.76% of the world's total population (Worldometer, 2022). The major project goals included:

- Spread awareness about COVID-19 issues and behavior
- Share the experience of countries with history of dealing with similar viruses;
- Help inform people by identifying pertinent topics to deal with COVID-19 and highlighting the importance of reliable and accurate information;
- Identify and share accurate and reliable information from authoritative information to fight misinformation and disinformation regarding COVID-19 and

The impact of the project was measured by collecting quantitative and qualitative data from the mixed methods approach.

Methods and Materials

The project was done in collaboration with The University of Hong Kong & Academy 22 for all with ASIS&T team members from Bangladesh, Hong Kong (China), India, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka.

45 videos on 10 pre-identified pertinent topics were created and uploaded in 5 languages- English, Bengali, Hindi, Sinhalese & Urdu.

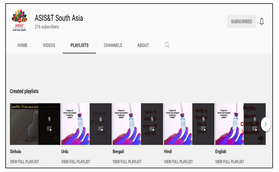

Figure 1. YouTube Channel Playlists

Figure 2. Video Content Creation

INTERVENTION DESIGN FOR ACTIONS FROM LOCAL TO INTERNATIONAL LEVELS

To disseminate the videos to people in Asia and beyond, a repertoire of online and offline initiatives was carried out with the videos as the intervention design for action from local to international levels for mitigating the infodemic from June 2021 to May 15, 2022. **6 online programs** were conducted to disseminate the videos and a series of intervention initiatives such as the **International Digital Story Writing Competition** (Fig.3), **Compete with Socrates 9Fig. 10)**', and **Covid-19 Knowledge Challenge**' was planned and executed.

A Series of Cross-boundary Webinars

To disseminate accurate COVID-19 knowledge, webinars with related topics were held in India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal, and Pakistan in November 2021. Parents, schoolteachers, and librarians of different areas benefited from professionals' sharing in the webinars.

Figure 3. IDSWC Flyer

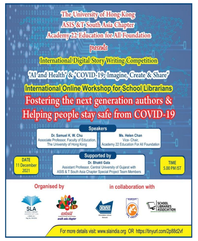

Figure 4a

Figure 4b

Figure 4c

Figure 4d

Figure 4e

Figure 4a- Promotional Webinar Posters from India, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, & Nepal

Results

International Digital Story Writing Competition

Launched **in October 2021** with the broad theme, "**AI, Robot and Health**" and Narrow theme, "**COVID-19: Imagine, Create & Share**", with focus on one recent health issue affecting the entire world, including stopping the spread of health misinformation and disinformation.

Ten free online workshops were held from Jan 1, 2022, to Mar 5, 2002, to prepare students for the Competition**. Judges from 7 countries** joined the International Digital Story Writing Competition judges' team. **1058 primary and secondary school students from 16 countries/regions** registered for this exciting event. **63 eBook submissions** were received from the primary and secondary school students of **9 countries/regions**.

Results

Compete With Socrates

The intervention to enhance the critical thinking skills of students in combating the COVID-19 infodemic, resulted in the questioning activity "Compete with Socrates" introduced to all International Digital Story Writing registrants after the seventh workshop on How to Learn the Art of Creating Questions.

COVID-19 Knowledge Challenge

After watching each of the 9 informative videos on combating COVID-19 and the infodemic, participants were asked to answer 3 questions. Those who passed this challenge and got at least 80% correct answers were awarded an electronic certificate to acknowledge their excellent knowledge in dealing with COVID-19. **98 children and adults, including Kindergartens, submitted their answers.**

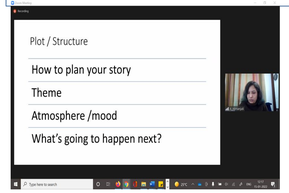

Figure 9. Workshop on How to write a story

Figure 10. Compete with Socrates

Conclusions

Information resilience is a precondition to building a resilient community (Chaudhuri, 2022).

In this poster, the strategies of responding to the information crisis, and employing interventions that protect against the infodemic and mitigate its harmful effects from local to international levels, were discussed to strengthen the resilience of individuals and communities to the infodemic for an information resilient Society.

Right actions for handling crisis, transition, and resilience for an information-resilient society are not limited to researchers, scientists, educators, and politicians. We're all in this together.

Contact

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